

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

ANY VACANCIES?

Looks like **Shashi Tharoor,** third-term Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram, is building a political life outside the Congress ecosystem after losing the party president election to Mallikarjun Kharge in October 2022. The 66-year-old recently inaugurated the Founder's Day celebrations of the Nair Service Society (NSS), a leading organisation of the influential Nair cohort in Kerala. The NSS, which earlier derided him as a 'Delhi Nair', now calls him a 'tharavadi' (aristocratic) one. And Tharoor, who took pride in calling himself a global citizen, says he is ready to become chief minister if the people of Kerala so demand. Ambition is certainly one thing Tharoor does not lack.

A GOOD WORD





Gujarat chief secretary **Pankaj Kumar**'s eight-month extension ends this month. Word is he'd like another extension, for which he is lobbying rather interestingly—promoting the prime minister's 'Mann Ki Baat' programme on radio Kumar is reportedly urging everyone, even visitors, to tune in. Meanwhile, another contender, **Vipul Mittra**, the seniormost IAS officer in the state who was secretary, tourism department, when Amitabh Bachchan endorsed the Gujarat Tourism campaign, has reportedly asked the veteran actor to put in a word at the PMO. Bachchan has earlier praised Mittra's books in his social media posts.

Mutt Ado

BJP national president **J.P. Nadda** recently went mutt-hopping in Karnataka, meeting seers from the Lingayat, Kuruba, Dalit and Valmiki communities in the Tumakuru, Davangere and Chitradurga districts. The hope was that meeting the pontiffs would pacify their respective communities who have been upset by the recent reservation controversies. Nadda was accompanied by Nalin Kateel, the local state unit chief, and Arun Singh, the national general secretary. The BJP chief, however, chose not to take either Chief Minister Basavaraj Bommai or his predecessor B.S. Yediyurappa when he visited the Lingayat mutt of Panchamasali Gurupeetha near Harihar. Sign of things to come?



ANI



Net Caste Wide

Nothing like fishing in troubled waters to catch a vote or two. So as the Rajput Karni Sena launched an agitation in Bhopal on January 8 for, among other things, reservations for its cohort, the Congress, with an eye on the Madhya Pradesh election later this year, ensured massive participation from the districts in which Congress-affiliated Rajput leaders hold sway. The BJP, worried that it would lose the influential community's affection and their votes, tried to pre-empt the Congress-supported show by holding its own Kshatriya Samagam at the chief minister's residence in the state capital on January 5, but with not as much success. The BJP state unit has now turned its attention to Dalits, encouraging them to hold public meetings. After all, every vote matters, Rajput or Dalit.

A UNITED SENA?

That all is not well between the BJP and chief minister Eknath Shinde's Balasahebanchi Shiv Sena (BSS) is no secret in Maharashtra. BSS leader and school education minister Deepak Kesarkar further set the cat among the pigeons when he said the two warring Senas—Shinde's and the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray)—could reunite if Uddhav did some '*atmapareekshan*' (introspection) on why a large number of them left. Not one to speak off the cuff, is this Kesarkar's bid to indicate that the doors to reconciliation are still open?

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Jumana Shah, Dhaval Kulkarni and Rahul Noronha